HOCKEY ▼

Let the Games Begin

With several major competitions lined up, the rest of 2026 looks pegged to be an eventful year for Indian women's hockey



Indian women's hockey team captain Salima Tete (right) and vice-captain Navneet Kaur (far right) are aware of their leading roles

A month since India sealed its spot for the 2026 Women's Hockey World Cup, captain Salima Tete and vice-captain Navneet Kaur are both elated and relieved. After all, they met one of the targets of Dutchman Sjoerd Marijne, coach of the famous Tokyo 2020 team, who was brought back in January to mould the team for an important year that also has the Asian Games scheduled in September. For the women, having a familiar face back in the dressing room was great. "He had worked with the team for five years, so he was acquainted with our culture, and he was happy to be back as well," says Kaur.

One would assume Marijne would be a tad miffed with the missed opportunities in the world cup qualifiers final against England, where the team failed to capitalise on the penalty corners, and also in the semis against Italy, where they scored one goal. Tete acknowledged the mistakes and the scope for improvement, but then again, it is early days in what's poised to be a busy calendar, with the Nations Cup also lined up. "Each game is important this year," says Tete, who, at 24, is already a senior member of the squad.

BADMINTON ▶

SHUTTLING AHEAD

India's badminton squad is all set for the upcoming Thomas and Uber Cups



ANI

A FINE RUN Ayush Shetty made it to the finals of the Badminton Asia Championships

When India lifted the Thomas Cup in 2022, Ayush Shetty was still testing the waters as a junior, with just one international tournament win under his belt. Four years on, he is India's next big singles hope as the team gears up for the championship on April 24. At the Badminton Asia Championships last week, the 20-year-old devoured the seeds at will, punchy yet patient, a sign of things to come. The World No. 25 also registered the most impressive scalp of his career—World No. 1 Kunlavut Vitidsarn in the semi-final—until falling short in the final against reigning world champion, Shi Yu Qi.

"I've been working a lot on my variations from the back court, mixing in half smashes